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Motivation for Planting a Church

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Motivation for Planting a Church

A. Motivation for planting must be in response to a personal vision and call from God.

1. This is always the first step. God must give you a glimpse of what He wants to accomplish. A vision may come from scripture, a dream, confirmation from others, prophecy, or an overwhelming burden for an area or group of people. (Acts 13, Acts 16:9-10)

Some church planters first respond to the call of God, but then become distracted. Some plant churches out of selfish ambition. Some church planters begin in response to the call of God, but then become driven by success.

People who are driven are:

1.

- a. Gratified by accomplishments.
- b. Consumed by symbols of success. (fame, wealth, power, worldly wisdom)
- c. Lacking in integrity. (immoral, selfish, prideful, demanding)
- d. Highly competitive. (2 Corinthians 10:12)
- e. Abnormally busy. (Luke 10:41-42)
- f. Willing to sacrifice relationship for activity.

2. If the vision, call or motivation to plant a church did not originate from God, there will almost certainly be failure. Knowing you are called is not just a good idea. It is absolutely crucial. (Psalm 127:1)

Being called is a work of the Holy Spirit, but being driven is a work of the flesh. The vision, call or motivation must always be rooted in response to the Holy Spirit.

B. Benefits of knowing you are called.

1. Focus of purpose by being colaborers. (1 Corinthians 3:9)

As a colaborer, we have Holy Spirit empowerment and help to accomplish the vision. Venturing out on our own without the Holy Spirit is a posture of presumption and isolation. Additionally, it is an act of pride and selfishness. Colaborers are quickly

reliant upon the Holy Spirit, and are not selfish in do not hoard acclaim or credit for success.

2. Blessings and provision. (Philippians 1:3-6)

Some have said, “Where God guides, He provides,” and others have said, “God pays for what He orders.” These sayings represent and affirm the truth of God’s faithfulness and provision. God’s name “Jehovah Jireh” in Genesis 22:14. The name is literally, The Lord Who Sees, or The Lord Who Will See To It. Provision and blessing are available and promised to those who are walking in obedience to God.

3. Faith and perseverance through trials. (Hebrews 12:1-3, 2 Thessalonians 3:5, James 1:2-4)

Our attempts to practice self-control over our actions and resist temptations to sin will never be completely successful this side of heaven. As long as we live as human beings, we will struggle with fallenness and sinfulness each and every day. We must remember that failures do not mean the end of our fruitfulness. Christ has a complete understanding of our weaknesses and limitations, and in Him we can receive new mercy every day (Hebrews 4:14-16, Lamentations 3:22- 23). As long as we confess and repent of our sins and shortcomings, God promises to cleanse, heal, and restore us. (1 John 1:9)

Paul writes, “. . . let us not grow weary while doing good, for in due season we shall reap if we do not lose heart” (Galatians 6:9). No matter how difficult your circumstances are, never lose faith in God’s purpose to see you through to the end. Persevere, looking to Christ for help and remembering always that trials will build your perseverance, and perseverance will make both you and your ministry into a strong witness for the faith.

C. Embracing the call and vision to plant.

1. The Lord can call you to church planting whether you are “receptive” or not.

- a. Moses was called to service from a burning bush.
- b. Gideon when he was threshing wheat.
- c. Jonah was called by God to go to Nineveh and proclaim repentance. However, Jonah ran away trying to escape God and the call to obedience.
- d. Obedience is better than sacrifice. (1 Samuel 15:20-26)

2. Pray for wisdom and ask clear and definitive questions of the Lord. (James 1:5,6b)

- a. Ask God if He is directing you to plant a church.
- b. Ask God where He is directing you to plant a church.
- c. Ask God when He is directing you to plant a church.
- d. Ask God how He is leading your to plant a church.

God is not afraid of your questions, and He is not afraid to answer you. Too often we fail to ask the right questions, and therefore, our response to His call may easily get off track. Even the apostle Paul was directed specifically by the guidance of the Holy Spirit to Macedonia. This was not Paul's original plan or intent, but God made it very clear that he was supposed to go and visit a man named Cornelius. By the leading of the Holy Spirit, there was already a man ready, waiting, and receptive to the Gospel. Asking for clear directions and wisdom is critical.

3. Seek counsel from Godly men, preferably three or four. (Proverbs 11:14)

- a. Be sure that at least two of them have experience in planting and pastoring a church.
- b. Ask for insight as to what they see as your strengths and weaknesses when it comes to potentially planting a church.

Counsel and wisdom from multiple experienced leaders will likely save you from heartache and potentially assist you in avoiding problems. People who have already walked down the path of church planting can share wisdom from their own success and failure.

Be quick to listen, but keep all counsel under prayerful consideration before you act (James 1:19). As others might point out potential downfalls or weakness they observe in your life, keep a posture of humility and receptivity. Do not take offense if you do not like the counsel you are given, but prayerfully submit the counsel to the Lord and ask for His confirmation and revelation.

4. Pray and fast, allowing God to direct your decision. (Acts 13)

- a. Ask the Holy Spirit to speak to you. (John 14:26a)
- b. Do not move, act or invent your own calling!

This sacrificial form of prayer produces powerful results. (Ezra 8:21-23; Isaiah 58:6) Throughout both Old and New Testaments, fasting and prayer was an expected discipline and always preceded great breakthroughs.

Moses fasted at least two recorded forty-day periods. Jesus fasted forty days and reminded his followers to fast. King David humbled himself in fasting. Believers are encouraged to fast to experience breakthrough, a more intimate relationship with Jesus, transformation, personal revival, and the supernatural.

Prayer and fasting is a necessary form of spiritual warfare. Whether in the early stages of planning the church plant or if you are already further along in the process – when it seems you have reached an insurmountable hurdle that you cannot overcome, it is likely time to fast and pray for a breakthrough.

5. Seek confirmation from your local church and leadership. (Acts 13)

- a. Paul and Barnabas were called out, recognized and their callings affirmed.
- b. Serving in a healthy local church will provide a similar opportunity for confirmation and commissioning.

If you are currently serving in a local church, submit yourself to the leadership and seek their affirmation. If you are not in a local church, but are studying as a Bible school student or are the only believer within your community, seek counsel and affirmation from other Christian leaders if possible.

Affirmation of your calling will often provide prayer, support and blessing as you are sent out to plant the church. However, if you make an attempt without seeking affirmation, your decision could be viewed as rebellion or an attempt to split the church.

6. Ask and expect inner peace as confirmation of the call. (John 14:27)

- a. After various practical confirmations, the church planter should be convinced and experience peace. (Philippians 4:6,7)

It is to be expected that there will be some level of apprehension or anxiety. However, this should not be a feeling that will immobilize you. God guarantees peace in supernatural portions. It is from this place that you can move forward with confidence.

Peace and unity need to reign in your heart as well as your spouse if you are married. The Lord blesses unity with peace, but you can be guaranteed if your spouse and family are not in unity, it is unlikely to experience true peace.

7. God does not speak to cause strife or confusion. Even when uncomfortable, God's direction will bring inner peace (Ephesians 1:17-18, Luke 10:21)

Direction from the Lord is often made very simple. Even though the greatness of God is very profound and incomprehensible, His directives are given to us in a way we can understand and implement.

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